How to Start a FEMINIST RESTAURANT

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TABLE OF CONTENTS

- Introduction: What Is a Feminist Restaurant and Why Would You Want to Start One? • *3*

SECTION 1: ENVISIONING YOUR RESTAURANT

- Defining Your Feminism • *5*
- What Are Your Goals for Creating This Restaurant? • *6*
- What Kind of Restaurant? • *7*
- Menu • *7*
- Liquor Licensing—and the Choice to Serve Alcohol • *8*

SECTION 2: MONEY, BUSINESS, AND CAPITALISM

- Feminism and the Relationship to Capitalism • *10*
- Funding • *10*
- Alternative Funding • *12*
- Permits • *14*
- Location—Gentrification/Relationship with Neighborhood • *15*
- Work Structure • *16*
- Tips • *17*
- Sourcing Necessary Items • *18*
- Aesthetics • *18*

SECTION 3: CONNECTION AND COMMUNITY

- Being a Community Center—Event Hosting, Group Meeting Space • *20*
- Being Part of a Larger Nexus of Feminist Businesses • *21*
- Diversifying Your Sources of Income • *22*
- Outreach and Advertising • *23*
- Gourmet Feminist Restaurants • *25*
- Final Advice • *26*
- If You Do Not Have the Capital • *27*
- Final Thoughts • *28*
- Want to Know More? • *28*
- About the Author • *29*

INTRODUCTION: WHAT IS A FEMINIST RESTAURANT AND WHY WOULD YOU WANT TO START ONE?

How can a restaurant be "feminist?"

There is a perception that feminists disdain the idea of women in the kitchen. Cooking has become the symbol of women's unpaid reproductive labor and the kitchen has become the representative location of women's subjugation. Even one of the most pervasive trolling taunts found throughout internet comment sections, "go make me a sandwich," serves to remind readers that a "woman's place" is barefoot, pregnant, and in the kitchen. However, food can be feminist and cooking can be a feminist act.

Food matters. We all eat. And the politics behind food and who prepares that food is important.

Feminist food politics consider the labor behind growing and raising food, processing or cooking ingredients, serving and consuming meals (and where this happens), and waste management. Feminist restaurants are spaces that take food and labor politics seriously. They challenge the status quo around cooking and consumption and provide a space for political organizing, recreational activity, and commerce. These restaurants support other feminist businesses and artistic endeavors, build communities, and connect pleasure and politics through serving "feminist food."

American and Canadian feminists have vocally challenged workplace inequity since the 1960s (and as part of labor movements since the late 19th century). The gender imbalance of restaurant owners, head chefs, and those who get praise and recognition for cooking continues to present-day. The restaurant industry is plagued by sexual harassment. Feminist restaurants seek to remedy these problems as well as provide a space where workers can support themselves financially while embodying their social justice values.

Over the past eight years I have read through the day planners, diaries, meeting minutes, account records, and business license applications of feminist restaurant owners. I have searched through mainstream

magazines and newspapers, read hundreds of feminist periodicals, flipped through thousands of event flyers, listened to recorded collective meetings, and conducted dozens of my own interviews. I meticulously searched through over fifty women's, lesbian, and gay travel guides to create a database, supplemented by advertisements, in order to build a series of maps showing where American and Canadian feminist restaurants and cafés of primarily the 1970s and 1980s were located. In 2015, I launched a website (thefeministrestaurantproject.com) showcasing my findings and wrote 450 pages of a doctoral dissertation on the topic which I am still editing.

I have had the benefit to glean knowledge of what makes an intentional feminist restaurant work and what to consider. I am not interested in telling you what to think or what to do, but in this guide I will suggest things to consider and questions you can ask yourself in the process of creating a feminist restaurant.

In my own research I have been particularly interested in spaces that call themselves "feminist" in either their title or advertising. Whether or not you decide to name your restaurant "feminist," this DIY guidebook provides useful tools for bringing social justice and feminist values into your endeavor.

SECTION I: ENVISIONING YOUR RESTAURANT

Defining Your Feminism

There are many types of feminism.

Marxist feminists tend to focus on economic and gender oppression with a focus on capitalism whereas *socialist feminists* broaden Marxist analysis and argue that both capitalism and sexism are equally oppressive. *Radical feminists* see patriarchy as the most trans-historical and cross-cultural form of oppression and believe that only through restructuring all institutions can equality be achieved. *Radical lesbian separatist feminists* believe that as it stands, society is so intrinsically misogynistic that the best course is to separate and form women-only communities. *Anarcha-feminists*, also called anarchist feminists, bring a gendered critique into anarchist theory and approach the struggle against state hierarchies as tied to gender and economics. *Ecofeminists* break into two groups: those that view women as being inherently closer to Mother Nature and those that also identify as feminist environmentalists and who view the extraction of the earth's natural resources as tied to the subjugation of women's bodies. *Liberal feminists* focus on political and legal reform and are less interested in tearing down institutions and are more invested in helping women move into positions of power. *Black feminism* ties together race, class, and gender oppressions. *Womanism* originates from black feminism and also seeks to critique racism within white feminist movements. *Intersectionality*, as coined by Kimberlé Crenshaw, brings together race, class, and gender analysis but also broadens feminism to address heterosexism, transphobia, ableism, ageism, and discrimination based on ethnicity, religion, immigration status, and more. *Indigenous feminisms* show that colonialism is intricately linked to social injustice and ties together intersectional feminisms with de-colonialism and indigenous sovereignty. There are debates between feminists involved in these separate groups as well as disagreements between feminists within these groups. These labels furthermore do not encompass all approaches to feminism. Each form of feminism has offered and continues to bring different strategies to tackle social injustice.

One of the first steps in creating a feminist restaurant is defining what *you* mean by "feminism."

I am not interested in imposing a single prescriptive definition of feminism when discussing feminist restaurants. For me, feminism is in the broadest sense about the social, political, and economic equity of all sexes and genders. Feminism seeks to create a socially just world and combat the forces of sexism, heterosexism, transphobia, racism, classism, ableism, and colonialism. Feminism also promotes environmentalism.

You will need to define what feminism means for you and how that will impact how you design your restaurant.

What Are Your Goals for Creating This Restaurant?

Historically feminist restaurants challenged labor conditions, workplace hierarchies, and exploitation of staff and customers.

What has drawn you to creating a feminist restaurant? Are you interested in challenging workplace structures? How? Do you want to found a restaurant that utilizes fair trade supply chains? What is the appeal in creating a feminist community space? Are you interested in promoting other kinds of feminist businesses in your local area? Why did you first decide to pick up this book?

When you are in the very initial stages of imagining your restaurant, it is time to dream big. At the start, write down all that you want to accomplish with your restaurant. As you actually begin to set up and operate your restaurant, the daily realities of having enough money, labor, time, and other resources will likely curtail your dreams. However, if you begin planning your restaurant by imagining your best-case scenarios, you will still provide yourself with a set of ideals to work towards. All small businesses face struggles and the ability to return to your list of all of the reasons you wanted to start the restaurant will help you endure the trials and tribulations.

What Kind of Restaurant? (Hours)

Feminist restaurants are "feminist" due to their approach to workplace dynamics, supply sourcing, wage structures, and the ability to foster and support community. They can be breakfast joints or specialize in meeting the needs of the lunch crowd. Perhaps you want your restaurant to specialize in dinners but open on Sunday mornings for brunch—go for it! Deciding on the kind of restaurant you want to open is a personal choice based on your perceived needs of the community, your goals for the space, and the kind of work schedule you want for yourself.

Benefits of restaurants open for:

Breakfast: Typically breakfast restaurants have a smaller menu with simple to cook menu items. Running this kind of restaurant will mean early wake ups.

Lunch: If your restaurant is located in an area surrounded by other businesses, you might be able to catch the "work crowd." Lunch foods can be quick to cook and may not even require an oven. Items such as sandwiches can be pre-assembled.

Dinner: It is easier to schedule shows and other kinds of live entertainment. Customers are typically willing to pay more for a dinner plate than a breakfast plate (see the section on cost). If you decide to serve alcohol (see the section on alcohol), diners are more likely to purchase it if your restaurant is open in the evening. Dinner plates, however, are typically more complicated to cook.

Menu

The menu will be very important for representing how your restaurant is feminist.

Historically, most feminist restaurants founded in the 1970s and 1980s in the USA and Canada viewed their menus as supporting their mission statement. Many, but not all, served only vegetarian or vegan food. For ecofeminists who believed that the oppression of animals and women were intrinsically linked, a meat-free menu was a must. For feminist restaurant owners that served meat, they still sold vegetarian food items.

Most feminist restaurant managers tried to offer inexpensive fare as women typically make less money than their male counterparts due to the wage gap. To compensate for class differences, some restaurants had daily specials at reduced costs or made the entire menu as affordable as possible. These choices lowered the profit margin for feminist restaurants more and placed them into a position of greater precarity. Furthermore, lower prices typically are associated with cheaper ingredients, which could contradict desires to source ingredients from local organic farms or from suppliers that treat workers fairly. Serving a seasonal menu, based on the produce readily available in your area, can reduce costs and environmental impacts by not needing to ship in apples from New Zealand. Investing in local farms furthermore makes a positive impact as it bolsters your local economy

In creating your menu it will be important to find a balance between the cost of materials, what you charge customers, and the kinds of foods that you are cooking. Since you are opening a feminist restaurant, instead of say, a feminist bookstore, thinking about the menu should be a high priority.

If food is a lower priority than creating a community space that just happens to be based around food, consider creating a simple menu of soup, bread, and dessert.

Liquor Licensing—and the Choice to Serve Alcohol

It will be important early on to decide if you intend to serve alcohol. Historically feminist restaurant and café owners were divided about this decision. Creating alcohol and chemical free spaces were personally important for communities that wanted to create alternative spaces to socialize apart from bar culture. Alcohol is a steady source of income and as feminist restaurants often run on a small profit margin, feminist restaurants can find more stability by serving alcohol.

If you decide to serve alcohol, you will have to obtain a liquor permit. There are usually two types: one that allows you to serve wine and beer and one that allows you to serve hard alcohol. Make sure to research your municipal laws early on in the planning process to understand

procedures for obtaining a permit. Local laws regarding booze vary drastically. Remember that if you choose to serve alcohol you may be excluding certain age groups or potential clientele.

SECTION 2: MONEY, BUSINESS, AND CAPITALISM

Feminism and the Relationship to Capitalism

In her 1974 business proposal, Patricia Hynes, founder of Bread and Roses Feminist Restaurant of Cambridge, Massachusetts, wrote, "As feminists, we are naturally opposed to capitalism. Though we cannot work outside the realities of American economic life, we hope as far as possible to operate as an alternative to business institutions as we have known them. Our main goal is not commercial; structurally we see the enterprise as a co-operative venture and one responsive to the needs of our community."

Feminists have historically had a fraught relationship with capitalism, as many feminists, particularly Marxist, Socialist, Radical, and Anarcha-feminists, have deemed capitalism as inherently intertwined with patriarchy. If economic and gender oppression intersect, is creating a feminist business a contradiction in terms?

One does not create a feminist restaurant with the intention of getting rich. Even while challenging oppressive economic structures, people need to create ways to economically support themselves in order to access shelter and food. By creating businesses that embody feminist principles, people are able to support themselves while staying true to their values.

Most critiques of capitalism are critiques of exploitation and not about the principle of business and exchange. As a result, a feminist restaurant that seeks to combat exploitation and promote social justice is not hypocritical but rather responsible.

Funding

According to Forbes, the cost to start a small restaurant in the United States is between $100,000 to 300,000 USD. How do you plan to raise that initial capital?

Most founders of feminist restaurants rely on a variety of types of funding.

Typical routes include:

1) *Bank loans:* While banks can offer a lower interest rate than some of the below options (depending on your other assets), banks are wary of backing first-time business owners and are especially reluctant to finance restaurants due to their high failure rate. Previous to the passing of the Equal Credit Opportunity Act in the United States in the 1974, most women could not get a line of credit in their own names, which proved especially difficult for single heterosexual women and lesbians trying to start businesses. Although banks in the United States are no longer legally allowed to discriminate on the basis of sex, there are other reasons you may be wary of relying on banks, due to their relationship to exploitative capitalism.

   Both the Canadian Small Business Financing Program and the US Small Business Loan Association make it easier for small businesses to get loans from financial institutions by sharing the risk with lenders.

2) *Credit cards:* Expect high interest rates. Credit cards can sink you into a hole of debt that may be hard to ever recover from. If you do have to rely on credit cards, make sure to pay them off as soon as possible. Similar to banks, you may be reluctant to support credit card companies due to their exploitative practices.

3) *Personal finances:* Most feminist restaurants begin with at least some of the founder's personal savings. If your business goes under, you will not be able to recover this money.

4) *Home equity loan/ Second mortgage:* If you are fortunate enough to own your own home, it is possible to uses your home as collateral, similar to a mortgage. The benefit of this kind of financing is that you do not need to know how the money is being used, and as a result, you can invest the money into your restaurant. However, if your business fails, not only have you lost the restaurant, but you have also lost your home.

The people that tend to be able to access these traditional forms of funding are the members of society with more privilege. Non-homeowners, with few personal savings, are less likely to be able to utilize these funding tactics. Even if banks are not legally allowed to discriminate on the basis of sex, race, ethnicity, or religion, this kind of discrimination occurs. Furthermore, depending on where you live, queer and gender-queer people can be legally discriminated against. As a result of your personal identity, your financial situation, and your personal politics, you may need to utilize alternative funding sources.

Alternative Funding

Most feminist restaurant founders have to utilize some form of alternative funding for their restaurant, even if they are combining it with mainstream funding sources.

1) *Credit Union Loans:* Are you uncomfortable with the idea of borrowing money from a bank? Credit unions can offer a solution. There even are credit unions that position themselves as specifically feminist or focused on social justice as part of their mandate.
2) *Crowdfunding:* If your feminist restaurant is attempting to fill a resource needed by the local community space, people may be willing to donate money towards getting it up and running. There are a variety of crowdfunding websites that can enable this kind of interaction, but be careful of fees on these sites.
3) *Micro-loans:* Friends and family may be willing to loan you money. Make sure that you set up the terms of the loan in writing in case these loans are ever contended.
4) *Promissory notes:* If you are establishing a feminist restaurant with a collective and if you each invest some of your personal money into the establishment, especially if you are all investing different amounts, you may want to consider using promissory notes. Promissory notes differ from IOUs in that they contain a specific promise to pay along with the steps and timeline for repayment as well as consequences if repayment fails.

5) *Selling shares of your restaurant:* If people donate a certain amount of money, they can "buy in" to the restaurant, which would mean that they would get a portion of your profits. Oftentimes, these investors will want to have a say in how the restaurant is run which can mean sharing control over the restaurant.

6) *Hosting fundraising events:* You might organize shows, events, concerts, raffles, and so forth in order to raise money for the restaurant before opening.

7) *Selling unofficial memberships:* Selling official memberships to a club to restrict clientele to members-only in the United States requires that you register as a 501(c)(3) or 501(c)(7) non-profit and in Canada as a nonprofit. As a non-profit you would technically be a club and not a restaurant. Although non-profits can make money to continue operations, your goal is not supposed to make money. As a non-profit, it makes sense to incorporate to be financially protected. However, if you want to operate your restaurant as a for-profit restaurant (as most restaurants are), you can sell unofficial memberships in which people with memberships pay an annual due, and save a certain percentage on their sales. The benefit of selling memberships is that you can have a sense of capital at the start of your fiscal year and people with memberships are likely to re-visit the restaurant regularly.

8) *Grants:* Look into possible small business grants in your local community. There are organizations that want to support people from marginalized communities to start businesses and if you are in one of these groups you may be able to access a variety of resources.

Permits

Depending on your location, starting any kind of restaurant requires numerous permits and licenses. Make sure you research the necessary documents for your local area. Regardless of your location, typically in the United States and Canada you will need to acquire some form of:

1) A Business License
2) An Employer Identification Number
3) Certificate of Occupancy
4) Food Service License
5) Sign Permit
6) Resale Permit
7) Building Health Permit
8) Employee Health Permit
9) Seller's Permit
10) Liquor Permit
11) Dumpster Permit/ Waste Disposal Permits
12) Live Entertainment Permit
13) Music License

Every municipality has its own regulations, so make sure to check with your local government officials about the necessary procedures. Speak with local business owners who have gone through the same procedures.

The government of Canada has a useful resource that lets you fill out an online form with the kind of business you wish to begin and your location so that you can access all of the required permits at: *canadabusiness.ca/search-permits*

For the United States, you can find information at the U.S. Small Business Association website: *www.sba.gov/blogs/how-find-right-license-and-permit-your-new-business*

Location—Gentrification/Relationship with Neighborhood

Your decisions over where you decide to lease can greatly impact your feminist restaurant. Typically the people who found feminist restaurants are on strict budgets and one of the greatest cost saving measures is finding an inexpensive lease.

While finding a location within your budge is important, it is important to be aware of the impact of your restaurant on the nearby community and businesses. Gentrification is the phenomenon that occurs when new businesses and development alters a neighborhood's characteristics and results in former long-term residents of that neighborhood to no longer be able to afford to remain in that area. Typically gentrification results in the displacement of racialized and working class communities. Will creating your restaurant lead to the gentrification of a neighborhood? Ideally you should find a location for your restaurant in an area where you are already part of the community.

Outreach to the neighborhood is important. How can you involve your neighbors with the creation of your restaurant? As food is a great way to build community and as you are opening a restaurant, can you organize events such as neighborhood block parties or invite people that live in the neighborhood into your space by offering discounts or some other kind of promotion?

Accessibility is an important factor in choosing a location. Is your space accessible for people with mobility disabilities? Is there a ramp and if not, is the landlord willing to add or let you add a ramp? Is your restaurant near public transit centers? Accessibility also relates to issues of class. Is your restaurant designed in a way that people from a variety of class backgrounds can visit the space?

IMPORTANT: Before you sign a lease, make sure that the building is properly zoned!!! Leasing space in improperly zoned buildings has led to the demise of a few feminist restaurants before they were even able to formally open.

Work Structure

As feminist restaurants have challenged the relationship with workplace hierarchies and how they have promoted sexist, classist, racist, heterosexist, and ableist ideologies, founders of feminist restaurants have experimented with workplace structure.

In the 1970s, collectives of three or more women typically managed feminist restaurants. Today, however, feminist restaurants tend to have one or two owners.

The benefits of collectives include disrupting hierarchical power structures, sharing of work, sharing costs, and uniting a group of people towards a common goal. There have been some successful collectives that have endured through the decades, despite changing economic, social, and political conditions. Successful collectives typically have created transparent divisions of labor, processes for dealing with conflicts, and have dedicated members. In studying collectives, I have found that many collective groups implode at around the 18-month mark due to infighting and issues with communication.

If you decide to manage your restaurant through a collective structure, it is important that you decide and agree ahead of time how decisions will made, how conflicts will be resolved, and how money matters will be dealt with. Will you rely on consensus, a clear majority, or will certain people's votes count as more? Will everyone who works at the restaurant get to vote or only the founding collective? Will you even hire other people to work at the restaurant or will jobs be restricted to the collective members? Writing all of these decisions down ahead of time can help with future disputes. Open and constructive communication is vital to collectives, as is empathy and forgiveness. Allowing for resentment to build between collective members will hasten the collective's downfall.

Whether or not you decide to manage your restaurant as a collective or with one or a couple of dedicated owners and managers, you will have to decide how you want to manage work roles.

Feminist restaurants have experimented with work structures by having each member of the staff rotate roles—such as someone manages the front of the house for a month, someone cooks for a month, someone

does the dishes for a month and so forth. Typically people tend to find certain tasks they prefer doing. It is helpful to have at least some consistency in having a person dedicated to managing accounts and food orders, even if choices about those realms are decided upon collectively. Having a set individual for those tasks will be useful as they will be dealing with distributers and other outside entities that may not be hip to your countercultural choices of collectivity.

Most feminist restaurants do not have waitresses. Part of this decision was to disrupt the power imbalances between servers and customers. Furthermore, by having customers go to a counter to order and pick up their own food, it reduces labor costs.

Other feminist restaurants bring food to the table but have customers return their dishes at the end of the meal.

I cannot emphasize how important it is to clearly outline labor roles in advance of not just opening your restaurant, but also before you begin any kind of fundraising or pre-opening work.

Tips

Tipping is a greatly debated subject in discussions about workers' rights in the restaurant industry in the United States and Canada. In the 1970s and 1980s, feminist restaurants typically banned tipping to eradicate the problematic power dynamic between staff and customers. Feminist restaurants typically aimed to pay a living wage for all employees and eliminate the need for the staff's livelihood to be dependent on the whims of customers. A common practice was to have a jar at the register for customers to donate loose change to support various feminist causes such as local non-profit organizations, women's sports leagues, environmental causes, etc.

Since it is a common practice for customers to anticipate the need to tip around 15% at the end of the meal, if you eliminate tipping, as a restaurant you will have to educate your customers about the new procedures. Signage or a note on the menu is one technique to educate your customers on these practices.

Sourcing Necessary Items

In addition to paying rent, wages, heating/cooling costs, and costs of ingredients you will need to outfit your restaurant. Restaurants require a lot of stuff: appliances, dishware, cleaning supplies, and so forth.

If you intend to buy all new appliances, you can estimate a price tag of over $100,000 USD. To save costs, you have a few options. It is possible to lease a location of a former restaurant that is already outfitted with all of the equipment. You will be less able to personalize the set-up, but costs will be lower. It is also possible to buy used equipment from estate and closure sales.

When restaurants go bankrupt, banks will hold public auctions to recuperate some of the losses. Here you can find deals on appliances. It is also worthwhile to go to estate sales for furniture and other furnishings for your establishment.

Before making any major purchases, be sure to research your municipal regulations and health codes as there may be restrictions about the kinds of equipment or tools that you are able to use. For example, you might have to use plastic spoons instead of wooden in the kitchen; you might be required to use appliances that can connect to a specific style of vent; and so forth. Learning these regulations in advance can save you money in the long run.

If you are a soup and sandwich place, you will require fewer appliances. When planning your menu, think about the kinds of equipment that you will need to support it.

Aesthetics

The aesthetic choices for your restaurant can be quite individualized. Customers and newspaper articles typically describe feminist restaurants as having a cozy, homey feeling. In part, this ambiance is the result of having a lower budget and a mismatch of furniture, cutlery, and accoutrement. In addition, a homey aesthetic can result by creating a restaurant that seeks to welcome customers, especially those from marginalized communities, to literally break bread together.

Your choice of decorations is a useful way to communicate your feminist values—the kinds of art you hang and informational posters you display can represent your mission statement.

The layout of the restaurant can both affect the ambiance and represent the values of the space. Easy to move furniture can be useful for re-arranging the space for special events and concerts. Long, shared tables invite customers to speak with one another.

An open kitchen is particularly common in feminist restaurants. By allowing customers to see the people who are cooking their food, the erasure of labor common in most restaurants is made visible. Likewise, the kind of emotional abuse common between members of the kitchen staff, which is a regular occurrence in the North American restaurant industry, is less likely to occur as customers can see what is happening in the kitchen.

If you have more than one dining room, perhaps each can have a theme, such as a quieter room during certain hours for customers seeking solace or one room where bands perform and the other as just a dining space. The choices are endless.

Your location will ultimately determine certain choices over layout and aesthetic.

SECTION 3: CONNECTION AND COMMUNITY

Being a Community Center—Event Hosting, Group Meeting Space

One of the most significant contributions feminist restaurants make is by acting as community centers. Feminist restaurants embody their feminism beyond challenging traditional restaurant work structures and menus. Feminist restaurants act as spaces, which support feminist artists and musicians. Typically, feminist restaurants host concerts, poetry readings, book readings, and workshops on social justice.

Events are a great way to bring new and different groups into the space.

Concerts: When designing your restaurant space itself, if you want to hold concerts, anticipate where you might have bands and performers set up their equipment. Concerts are a great way to support both local and touring musicians. If you are not connected to the music scene of your local area already, you can post flyers in the restaurant and connect with performers in your region and let them know that the space is now available. Remember to also check with your municipal laws as you may be required to have a permit for concerts. Most feminist restaurants allow performers to use their stage free of charge or take only a small percentage of door sales if there are tickets sold for the show.

Book readings and poetry readings: Similar to concerts, you will need a space for the author to read. Having some kind of equipment to enable amplification, such as a microphone and speakers, will be useful. Consider having a table for the author to sell copies of their book from after the meeting.

Hosting a coffeehouse night: You can invite people in your community to an open mic night where people take turns playing music, reading poetry, and performing other kinds of art. These nights work wonderfully as fundraisers either for the restaurant or for special causes and charities.

Social justice and educational programming: Consider inviting activists to facilitate workshops on social justice causes as broad as teaching about what intersectionality means or current political matters such as an environmental concern relevant to your region. Using your restaurant as a space for workshops, either during or off regular opening hours, is

a way for you to use your space to promote social justice and accessible education.

Space for local groups: A great way to build in a guaranteed clientele is to offer your space for use by local groups. Feminist restaurants have served as the weekly meeting spot for Queer AA, Lesbian mothers club, chapters of Save the Wetlands, and many others. These groups typically meet at the restaurant at the same time each week and will likely purchase teas, coffees, baked goods, etc. from the restaurant. You can even negotiate a special discount for the group.

Sponsoring groups outside the restaurant: Feminist restaurants will sponsor local sports teams and other organizations that will wear t-shirts with the restaurant's name (added publicity) and will have their post-game parties at the restaurant.

Art on the Walls: A simple way to promote local artists, especially those from marginalized groups that are less likely to get exposure at mainstream galleries, is to hang art on your walls that is for sale. You may work out an arrangement where the restaurant takes a small commission for the art—or not.

Other Matters To Consider

Cost: To keep events accessible, be conscientious of ticket prices, cover charges, and so forth, consider utilizing a sliding scale or discounts for seniors and students. You can also offer work exchange for more expensive events—where a person might get free entrance to the event but they have to work the door for an hour or help with the dishes.

Calendar: If you are interested in having frequent events, it will be useful to have a community event calendar that is available to your listserve and social media pages, and also available as a physical copy.

Outsourcing Event Hosting: Maybe you love the idea of having lots of events in your space but it is not your area of expertise. You may find that someone in your community is interested in acting as an events coordinator for your restaurant. People with different skillsets surround you. You do not have to be an expert at everything. Delegate.

Bulletin Board: I strongly suggest that you have a bulletin board somewhere in your restaurant, both to promote events happening in your space but also to provide other community groups an opportunity to advertise.

Being Part of a Larger Nexus of Feminist Businesses

Historically feminist restaurants relied on other feminist businesses for support while also bolstering their peer institutions. Feminist restaurants borrowed money from feminist credit unions, co-hosted events with feminist bookstores, advertised in feminist periodicals and sold copies of those same periodicals in return, and more.

One point that I have been trying to emphasize throughout this guide is that one of the greatest contributions feminist restaurants make is by connecting members of the community and related businesses together. Maybe your town does not have a feminist bookstore—most feminist bookstores were wiped out during the 1990s when independent bookstores were hit hard by economic changes and the rise of the superstore and later online book retailers. However, is there a nearby coffee shop or store that promotes social justice values that you can collaborate with to co-host an event? Can you loan your space for a community group to host a fundraiser? Can you have a space where activists can leave leaflets? Is it possible to source your produce from local farmers and products from nearby suppliers?

How can you support other businesses? Not only is choosing to support your local economy an embodiment of certain feminist principles, but you may also find that by investing in others, they will also invest in you. We rise together.

Diversifying Your Sources of Income

As discussed earlier, restaurants operate on a low profit margin and are thus economically vulnerable. Feminist restaurants often try to run another side business to help add stability to the restaurant. Some feminist restaurants function simultaneously as feminist bookstores,

some sell feminist art and music, while others offer catering services. If you decide to host music functions, consider taking a small percentage of ticket sales. Feminist restaurant owners may also use the space of the restaurant to promote their other ventures such as selling their art, cookbooks filled with recipes of the restaurant, calendars, and more!

Outreach and Advertising

Ideally, you will already be connected to an active feminist network of support, as being part of a community already will make financing and publicizing your restaurant easier. You will still likely need to do some form of publicity.

Advertising can be as simple or intricate as you desire. New technologies are constantly changing the ways that restaurant owners choose to advertise. From the outset, it is useful to create a cohesive design and strategy. Creating a logo, which you can place on all of your digital and physical materials, is a simple step to creating this kind of cohesion.

Where and how you decide to advertise can embody your feminist principles.

Digital

Social Media: Most contemporary feminist restaurants take advantage of social media and create a Facebook Page, an Instagram account, and perhaps a Twitter handle. The benefit of utilizing these platforms is that they are free. On the other hand there are valid critiques of these applications as they profit by selling personal data, benefit a few corporations, and lead to a further concentration of wealth in the hands of a few.

Website: It is common for restaurants to have websites in order to advertise their hours, location, menu, and other details as deemed necessary.

Build your search engine optimization (SEO): If you have created a website, you want to help people find it as easily as possible. Make sure to take simple steps such as registering your site with Google Webmaster

Tools and Bing Webmaster. Do not hide keywords within images as that text will not be read by search features.

Restaurant finder tools: Register your restaurant on tripadvisor.com, Google's My Business, Yelp, and similar sites.

Blogging: You can create a blog to write about matters that are important to you and also promote your restaurant.

Buying digital ad space: It is possible to buy ad space through social media providers that can target customers in your local area. Facebook and its peers make this process incredibly easy and have handy how-to guides. It is also possible to buy ad space for digital publications or even produce sponsored content (articles that fit the tone of a website but are actually advertisements).

Listserve: If your restaurant hosts special events, concerts, and shows, create an email listserve to keep customers up to date on the upcoming events happening in the space.

Physical

Signage: A well marked, easy to read sign out front is a simple form of advertisement.

Buying hard ad space: You can look into buying ad space in newspapers and periodicals. Local counter cultural publications often rely on advertising revenue, so buying ad space from them can help support these endeavors.

Flyering: Especially if you live in a walkable city, consider posting flyers about your restaurant. This technique is particularly useful if you have some kind of special event, like a Grand Opening or a show occurring in your space.

Working events: Before your launch, you might consider catering local events that bring in people that are part of your intentional demographic.

Promotions: Offering special promotions such as discounts and new menu items can drum up new business.

Collaborate: Team up with another feminist business or organization in your local area and promote each other's work, both at each group's physical space, but also in your other advertising.

Business cards: Business cards might seem a tad old fashioned but they are inexpensive to print and can be very useful.

Ideally your products will work as advertisements for your restaurant itself. Branding your materials with your logo or address can bring in new clientele.

Other Tips

To create a cohesive design, consider hiring a graphic designer with web design skills. You have the opportunity to support an artist in your community and they can likely do the design work more efficiently than you.

Begin advertising and drumming up excitement for your restaurant long before you even open. Every fundraising event you hold in advance is also a chance to advertise your space.

To make future customers feel included, solicit suggestions for what they want from the feminist restaurant.

Is It Possible to Have a Gourmet Feminist Restaurant?

Can there be such a thing as an haute-cuisine feminist restaurant? To be a feminist restaurant, is there a requirement to serve healthy and vegan food? Is it possible to create feminist restaurant spaces that do gourmet cuisine but which do not replicate the problematic labor power dynamics of mainstream male-centric kitchens and dining rooms?

Short answer: It depends. It depends on your feminism.

Longer answer: This guide began with the section "defining your feminism" and continued to explain the various aspects of the restaurant business that feminists have sought to challenge and transform. Whether discussing the cost of menu items, the advantages and disadvantages of managing a restaurant collectively, or how to use the café space as a community center, this document has emphasized that all of the

decisions you make around these topics will be intrinsically linked to your feminism and your goals for the restaurant.

It is important to ask yourself why you want to create a gourmet restaurant. If the desire were to offer clients a certain selection of dishes, then the next step to creating a feminist restaurant with a gourmet menu would be figuring out a way to source your ingredients in an ethical manner. You also have to address issues of accessibility. Most gourmet restaurants depend on ideals of elitism and exclusion. How can you design your restaurant in a way that you can serve the kinds of food that you want without reifying class divides?

Feminist restaurant founders created spaces that embodied their feminism in different ways. With these restaurants, feminism is an ideal that one is *striving towards*. The feminism for feminist restaurants is not static but is a process.

As this guide noted in the beginning, economic conditions and time constraints may curtail some of your dreams. Your feminist ideals in creating this restaurant are something that you will continually build upon and sort through.

Final Advice

When former feminist restaurant owners reflected on what they wished they had known before starting their businesses, here were some of their thoughts.

- Know that the restaurant will consume all of your time at least for the first year, but likely for the first two years.
- The process will be easier if you have more start up capital when beginning.
- Many money saving measures, such as leasing a run-down property that requires significant renovations, will mean more labor hours. Anticipate that many choices that save money will cost time.
- Hire a lawyer. A lawyer will help you sort through the necessary legal documents for structuring your business and making sure

that you are following correct procedures. The initial cost of legal fees will save you money in the long run.

- Hire an accountant to help you set up your books and financial structure. Fortunately, there are useful applications available to small business owners to help with operations, such as online platforms that sync with your bank accounts and allow you track all financial activity. Whether or not you have an accountant, you will need to itemize your deposits and withdrawals.
- If working in a collective, hire a mediator or therapist to partake in process meetings where you can sort out interpersonal issues that otherwise might be buried when everyone is fixated on the day-to-day operations.
- Know how to buy and produce food efficiently.
- Get your liquor license early if you plan to sell alcohol.
- Anticipate bureaucratic sluggishness. Make sure your paperwork is completed properly and organized early, as this will reduce bureaucratic wait times.

If You Do Not Have the Capital... Open a coffeehouse!

Opening a feminist restaurant is a huge undertaking. If you do not have the start up capital to begin a business of this scale, consider opening a coffeehouse! Feminist coffeehouses vary from a single event to a re-occurring happening. Coffeehouses typically feature live music, poetry or book readings, art displays, or guest speakers and workshops and happen in spaces rented for the period of the event, such as community center meeting rooms, lobbies of feminist bookstores, at libraries, and more! Occasionally, light fare and coffee/tea is served. You will still need to figure out details such as finding and renting a location, designing a schedule/program, sourcing the food and selling it, fundraising and ticket sales, musical equipment and sound system rentals, and more. A coffeehouse can be a great way to experiment with some of your ideas before jumping into the restaurant business.

FINAL THOUGHTS

Feminist restaurants allow their founders to create spaces that invest in local communities. These restaurants and cafés promote other feminist businesses and social justice organizations. They create a space where people can socialize, work on activist causes, and enjoy art and culture together.

Eating is one of the most basic parts of being human. What could be more beautiful than bringing people together into a feminist space that fosters community in order to share food and drink?!

I am continually inspired by the wonderful women who have founded and continue to operate feminist restaurants. I wish you the best as you begin your journey starting a feminist restaurant, café, or coffeehouse.

APPENDIX

Want To Know More?

Historical Context

If you are interested in learning more about the history of feminist restaurants and cafés in the United States and Canada, check out my website, *thefeministrestaurantproject.com*

Want to Visit a Feminist Restaurant?

Bloodroot Feminist Vegetarian Restaurant of Bridgeport, Connecticut has been serving feminist fare since 1977. Visit them at: 85 Ferris Street, Bridgeport, Connecticut. To find up to date hours of operation, see: *bloodroot.com*

Since 1980, The Big Kitchen of San Diego, California has brought together the Southern California community over tasty eats at 3003 Grape Street, San Diego, California, *bigkitchencafe.com*

Lagusta's Luscious Vegan Chocolate Shop and Commissary is definitively feminist and part of a new generation of feminist restaurants (founded in 2003). It is located at 25 North Front Street, New Paltz, New York. Check out *lagustasluscious.com*

ABOUT THE AUTHOR

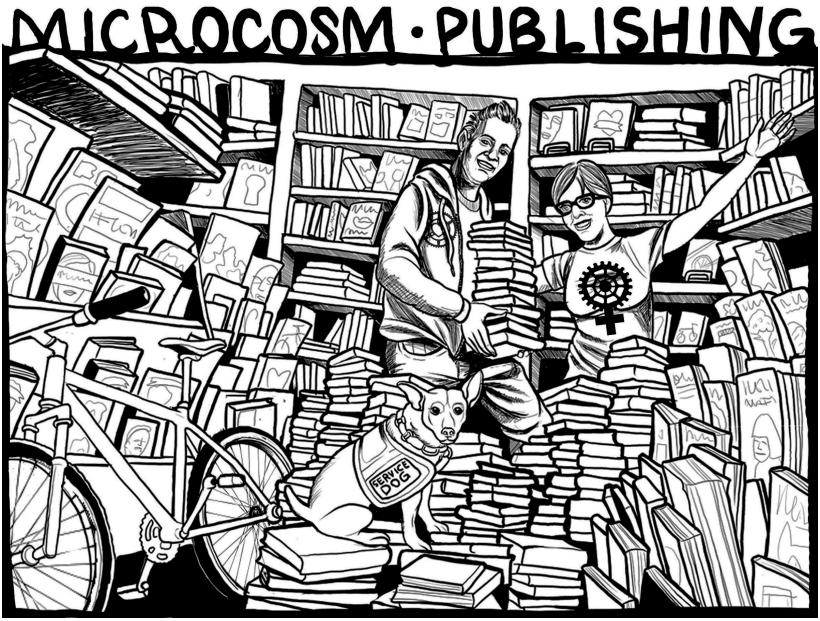
Alex D. Ketchum is a PhD candidate in the Department of History at McGill University focusing on feminisst restaurants, cafés, and coffeehouses in the United States and Canada from the 1970s to present day. Her work integrates food, environmental, and gender history. She has a MA in History and Women and Gender Studies also from McGill University and an Honors BA in Feminist, Gender, and Sexuality Studies from Wesleyan University. Her research is made publicly available at The Feminist Restaurant Project (*thefeminisrestaurantproject.com*). At McGill University, she teaches in the Gender, Sexuality, Feminist, and Social Justice Studies Program. In addition to her dissertation research, she is founder and editor of The Historical Cooking Project (*historicalcookingproject.com*), a website dedicated to food history scholarship, and co-founder of Food, Feminism, and Fermentation (*foodfeminismfermentation.com*), an organization which hosts the annual Leavening the Conversation Conference. She is actively involved in feminist, food, and environmental politics. She co-organized operations on an organic farm from 2008-2012 and has worked on organic farms in Ireland and France. In 2009, she founded Farm House in Middletown, Connecticut, a living community dedicated to food politics work that continues today.

THANK YOU

I am indebted to the feminist restaurant and café owners, the archivists and librarians, my doctoral supervisors and writing committee, and my friends and family for supporting my research.

To the women who started and to the people who will start feminist restaurants, you inspire me.

ABOUT THE PUBLISHER



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During a time when much attention has been given to sexual harassment and labor issues in the restaurant industry, How to Start a Feminist Restaurant is a DIY/DIT guide for creating your own feminist restaurant, cafe, or coffeehouse.

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